THE GIFTS OF LOVE?

The ED's listing of gifts given by Sukash to Jacqueline

- 20 pieces of jewellery, 36 bags, 5 watches, 65 pairs of shoes, 47 dresses, 9 paintings, 1 crockery set **Rs 5.8 crore**
- Horse worth **Rs 57 lakh**; allotment of stable and membership fee for the horse at the Mahalaxmi Race Course worth **Rs 7 lakh**
- Four Persian cats **Rs 9 lakh**
- Advance payment to a scriptwriter on behalf of Jacqueline **Rs 15 lakh**
- BMW XS car for her US-based sister Geraldine J. Walker **Rs 1.26 crore**
- Two vehicles–a Porsche and a Maserati–for her parents in Bahrain* **Rs 1.89 crore**
- An SUV for her Australia-based brother, Warren J Fernandez **Rs 15 lakh**
- A house for her parents in Bahrain*; token money for a house for Jacqueline in Juhu*; Negotiating to buy a house for Jacqueline in Sri Lanka* **NA**

**Money trail to these gifts has not been established yet*

Originally from the Pazhanganatham hamlet in Madurai, the family lived in rented accommodation in Bengaluru's Chandra Layout locality. Devaraja, who first raided Sukash's home in 2011, remembers it as a modest lower middle-income household. Keen that their only child have a good education, Sukash's parents sent him to the upscale Baldwin Boys' High School in the city. While his classmates came to school in big fancy cars, Sukash would be dropped to school on his father's scooter. Perhaps this early experience of socio-economic disparity led him to aspire for a more opulent lifestyle.

No one knows where Sukash picked up his first lessons in the art of the con. He had committed his first forgery even before he was eligible to apply for a driving licence. In April 2006, he forged the signature of the then police commissioner on a letter saying that he was allowed to drive cars and bikes anywhere in Karnataka. Some suspect his parents played a part in his education as a conman—they have been arrested thrice along with him, including in the very first con Sukash pulled.

In August 2007, the Bangalore police arrested Sukash and his parents for cheating a 76-year-old man of Rs 1.15 crore. They had allegedly promised the desperate man that they would help him free a plot of land acquired by the Bangalore Development Authority and even secure foreign investment for the construction of an apartment. Sukash claimed he was friends with Nikhil Gowda, son of the then Karnataka chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy. He apparently used the loot to buy five cars, including a BMW, and 12 watches. The family was out on bail soon and recently even got an acquittal in a lower court.

School had taught Sukash something else—the perks of privilege. The parents of some of his classmates were government servants. Fascinated by the doors that power and privilege opened up, he apparently became a careful observer of people of this class, imbibing their body language and mannerisms. After his first caper in 2007, Sukash allegedly began frequenting places where bureaucrats, businessman and politicians socialised. And it was in these elite hangouts that Sukash began absorbing information on government machinery, bureaucratic hierarchy, tendering practices and brokering. The cars he drove and the money he flaunted helped.

He then began carefully choosing his targets, researching them meticulously first. "Often, he knew more about the victims than they knew about themselves," a Delhi Police official reveals.

Sukash's first con came before he was old enough to drive, forging the sign of a police commissioner on a letter that gave him licence to vroom

"He primarily targeted people who were either greedy or had a difficult job to be done. It could be a contract or a court case or even a school admission." Along with the fancy cars, he also began living in upscale areas on rent and moving around with a gunman to impress unsuspecting victims. It's a different matter that he once allegedly did not pay a gunman the salary he had promised him.

Most often, he would introduce himself as a relative of the person who could possibly get the job done for the victim. A Bangalorean recalls how when he first saw Sukash sitting one table away in a coffee shop, he was promising his unsuspecting victim admission for his son in a reputed school. He grandly claimed that he was the son of the school owner.